



# AMONG THE LAST OF THE INDIGENOUS PEOPLES who once populated the Panama coast, the Kuna people now live mainly in the islands of the nearby San Blas archipelago. Some elements of their culture are probably of ancient origin; reflecting a

# KUNA

## FRAGMENTS OF A LOST WORLD

### Independent nation

The land inhabited by the Kuna people is known as the Comarca of Kuna Yala (“Kuna Yala” means “Kuna Land”). Since 1938, it has been a self-governing area within the country of Panama, making this the first indigenous group in modern Central America to exercise political control over its own territory.

### WOMEN'S WORLD

Kuna society places great value on women—female children are highly desired, daughters tend to inherit family houses, and a husband moves in with his wife's family. One clear expression of this attitude is the fact that women's dress is much more elaborate, colorful, and symbolic than men's clothing.

### DIVING FOR GOLD

One uniquely modern tradition involves the luxury ships that constantly cruise the Caribbean. Kuna youngsters row out to meet them, and the passengers throw coins in their direction.



Gold nose rings indicate a woman's status.

From the time of puberty, Kuna girls have their arms and legs tightly bound in beaded wrappings.

### DANCING WITH THE PAST

The Kuna value tradition highly, and their culture provides customs and rituals for most life events. Often, these customs are passed along the generations through chants and dances.

### ISLANDS IN THE SUN

Kuna Yala consists of 365 islands like this one, and a strip of land on the adjacent Atlantic coast. With the help of environmental groups, the Kuna have established a 232 sq mile (600 sq km) forest reserve on their territory.

